

The article begins with the description of loneliness and how impactful it is in modern society. The authors provide overall context to AI and its origin as psychotherapeutic treatment. The authors bring up a lot of statistical evidence, stated from surveys about user experiences with psychotherapeutic AI systems, they state “Notably, 3% of the respondents in this study even stated that interactions with Replika ‘halted their suicidal ideation’”, this shows that they acknowledge the positive affects LLMs can have in this field. After, they start going into the more negative, or lacking effects of socializing with an LLM have on humans.

Their next appeal could be argued as Ethos. Everyone has experienced the “excitement” surrounding new technology. It’s something that readers can relate to and use their own experiences to confirm the validity of their statement. The overall message of the article is that Artificial Intelligence should not be used as a stand in for human connection.

The authors start going into the core reason of their beliefs on LLMs as companions. There is a bit of ethos noting that the importance of human to human touch and interaction has been something that has been studied for centuries. They even cite a large text about COVID-19 and how the lack of physical touch can cause psychological problems. Logos is connecting that to the lack of human to human interaction that LLMs provide, while not dismissing their ability to verbally mimic human conversation. There are further Logos with this point by demonstrating how important body language is for humans. Without seeing a person in front of you, moving a certain way, there is a disconnect between you and that person. Usually, when you are in a room with someone, their emotions are “contagious” as these researchers put it. This article relies heavily on people having empathy to understand the more complex aspects of human emotion.

This point is also tied with ethos because of this need to understand the experiences being spoken about in this article.

The last and probably most important point they make is about how LLMs are merely a bandaid on the loneliness epidemic. LLMs are only substitutes for real human connection and that is the real core reason why LLMs should not replace humans in terms of relationships. Instead of encouraging interaction in the real world, it is only sealing people off from attaining the real thing. LLMs are the safe and easy option to cover up a real societal problem. This appeal is both logos and ethos. It serves as almost a call to action for the reader to not use LLMs in such a way in the future. In the end it doesn't matter how advanced the technology gets in simulating a real relationship, it is still ignoring the core social issues in our society today.

Montag, C., Spapé, M., & Becker, B. (2025, September 16). Can AI really help solve the loneliness epidemic? [Review of Can AI really help solve the loneliness epidemic?].

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